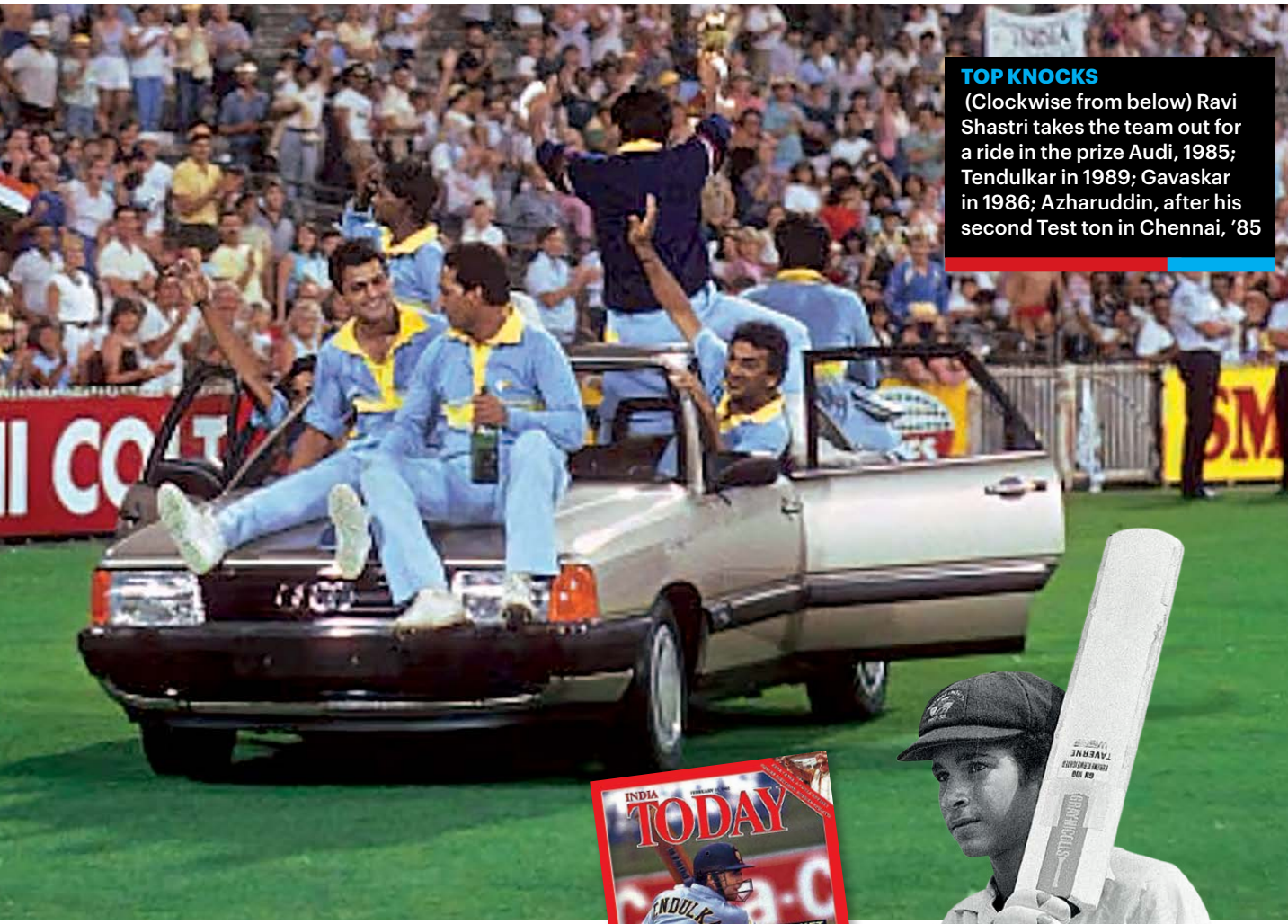
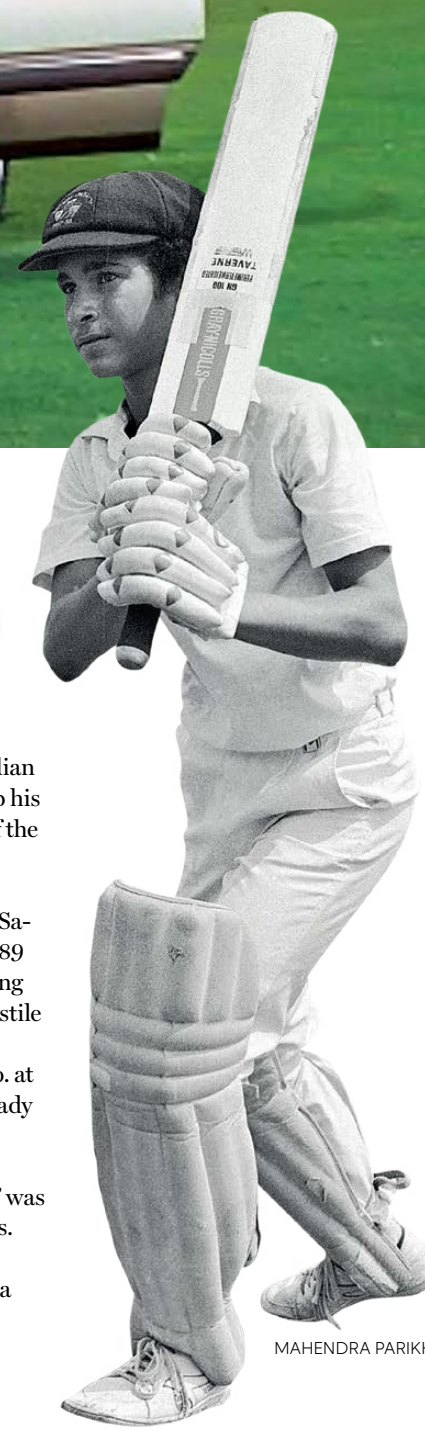


TOP KNOCKS
(Clockwise from below) Ravi Shastri takes the team out for a ride in the prize Audi, 1985; Tendulkar in 1989; Gavaskar in 1986; Azharuddin, after his second Test ton in Chennai, '85

GETTY IMAGES



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MAHENDRA PARIKH

Change was in the air. That became evident in the first weeks of 1985 itself when Mohammed Azharuddin, a wiry 21-year-old from Hyderabad with seemingly elastic wrists, hit three hundreds in his first three Tests—a feat unsurpassed till today). By March, India had announced to the world that 1983 was no 'fluke', winning the Benson & Hedges World Championship on a new stage where white balls, colour uniforms, D/N (day-night) matches and new rules prevailed.

And by 1987, the cricket world knew where the money was too, with the World Cup moving out of England for the first time, and Reliance coming onboard as sponsor. But for India's sports fans, it was to be a so-near-yet-so-far kind of year, losing in the WC cricket semis and also getting blanked by the Swedes in the tennis Davis Cup final after much heroics to reach there. The year also saw an Indian colossus, Sunil Gavaskar, hanging up his pads, having by then broken many of the Test batting records of the time.

But as one Little Master left the pitch, another was set to take strike. Sachin Tendulkar was a tender 16 in 1989 as he took guard at the crease, showing 'remarkable composure' against a hostile Pakistan attack. By the 1990 tour of England and the 'magisterial' 119 n.o. at Old Trafford, comparisons were already being drawn with the young SG. The legend only grew from there.

Meanwhile, the 'Payyoli Express' was lighting up the track-and-field arenas. After the 1/100th of a second heart-break at the 1984 Olympics, P.T. Usha